FOR IMMEDIATE RELEASE

News Release: UNL Student named USA Today Scholarly Genius Award Winner

Sunday, 16 February 2025

Lincoln, NE / February, 16 September 2025 / Cameron Kunz, an Advertising and Public Relations major at the University of Nebraska-Lincoln, is named the winner of the American Scholarly Genius Award. Kunz is selected from a pool of 75,000 applicants.

Kunz, wins the award after submitting a 10,000-word essay titled “Civility is Our Strength.” The essay points towards civility being the cornerstone of democracy in the United States and argues respect should be the foundation of disagreement. Kunz was notified of his victory on Saturday, February 15, 2025.

“Kunz’s essay serves as a stark reminder that how we talk to each other matters,” said Adam Wagler, interim dean of the College of Journalism and Mass Communications. “Our college embodies the standards Kunz alludes to in his essay, and we are beyond proud to host this achievement.”

The purpose of the competition is to highlight how current generation students view the future of democracy in the United States. Donors that support USA Today sponsor scholarships for the award.

“Winning this award means so much beyond words to me,” Kunz said. “Being able to highlight how our future can be bright through the lens of civility is something that means so much to me.”

Those interested in reading the award-winning essay can be read at USA Today’s website.

The College of Journalism and Mass Communications at the University of Nebraska-Lincoln prepares students for careers in journalism, advertising and public relations, broadcasting and sports media. Learn more at journalism.unl.edu.

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